

Week 3 Enabling Activities

Causal Systems

This set covers the full six-activity family for Causal Systems, organized as two tracks: 1a–1c build the Trigger → Mechanism → Downstream Effect move in stages; 4a–4c test whether it has proceduralized. These supplement — they do not replace — this week's folder and the ESO/Frames Daily Protocol.

This Week's Frame — Causal Systems (W3)

Trigger	Mechanism	Downstream Effect
What sets the causal chain in motion?	How does the effect actually get produced?	What results at the end of the chain?

Key requirement: the mechanism step must be explicit. A response that names the trigger and the downstream effect but skips how one produces the other is operating at ILR 2+, not ILR 3. The causal chain must be traceable step by step.

Activity Index

1a. Single-Scenario Depth Ladder · 1b. Sentence-Frame Progression · 1c. 3-Interval Comparison & Paraphrase · 4a. 2-Box Induction · 4b. Silent Protocol & Brief-Back · 4c. Strategic Competence & Fallback

Single-Scenario Depth Ladder — "Scaffold the Scaffold"

Holds one low-stakes scenario constant while building the Trigger → Mechanism → Downstream Effect move in four steps. Use before a student's first W3 attempt, or as remediation if the mechanism step isn't yet explicit.

ANCHOR SCENARIO (HELD CONSTANT ACROSS ALL FOUR ITEMS)

A city introduces a tax on sugary drinks.

1

Surface

"What triggers a change in behavior when the city introduces the tax?"

Name one trigger only.

2

Surface → Deep

"What is the downstream effect, in the end?"

Add the Downstream Effect box. Trigger and effect only — don't explain how they connect yet.

3

Deep

"The tax raises the price of sugary drinks. This leads many consumers to ____, which over time reduces population-level sugary consumption."

Complete the Mechanism — the missing middle step connecting trigger to effect.

4

Transfer

"Should cities also tax sugary snacks, not just drinks?"

Full response: trigger + mechanism + downstream effect, no connector given.

Instructor note: 5–10 minute warm-up. A student who completes Item 4 without hesitation is ready for the Week 3 folder.

Causal Subordination → Concessive Subordination → Appositive

Builds subordinate-clause complexity in three tiers using connectors that read as ILR 2+/3, not just connectors that are technically subordinating. Coordinating conjunctions (FANBOYS) are excluded — and so are 'because' and 'so': both are grammatically fine, but they're exactly the safe, overused connectors that inflate a proficiency ceiling. T1 uses higher-register causal subordinators with more precision.

SCENARIO

A city introduces a tax on sugary drinks.

T1

Causal subordination — given that / on the grounds that / considering that

Complete each sentence, naming one trigger.

- "Consumers switch to water and diet drinks given that ____."
- "Retailers stock more low-sugar alternatives on the grounds that ____."
- "Health officials expect the policy to work considering that ____."

T2

Concessive subordination — although / while / even though

Hold the immediate reaction and the downstream effect in tension inside one sentence.

- "While the tax raises prices immediately, the real health impact ____."
- "Although sales of sugary drinks drop right away, population-level health outcomes ____."
- "Even though the trigger is simple — a price increase — the mechanism that produces the effect ____."

T3

Appositives — "Fact, ____, Fact"

Embed a trigger's or effect's role in the causal chain as a defining phrase inside the sentence.

MODEL

"The price increase, the immediate trigger for changed shopping habits, pushes many households toward cheaper alternatives while the resulting drop in sugar consumption, compounding gradually across the population, only shows up in health statistics later."

Instructor note: 'because' and 'so' aren't FANBOYS, but they're the safe, overused connectors that flag a proficiency ceiling. T1 swaps them for 'given that' / 'on the grounds that' / 'considering that' — same causal entry point, higher register from the first sentence. Move to T2 only once T1 is fluent. T3 stretch — optional for students still consolidating the core requirement.

Comparison & Paraphrase Prompts

Connects causal-chain vocabulary to comparative sentence structures, moving from a simple one-line comparison to a claim that explicitly traces trigger to downstream effect.

COMPARISON PAIR

How the tax's immediate effect on drink sales compares with its downstream effect on public health.

Target Lexicon — must appear at least once

mechanism

triggers

in turn

downstream

as a
direct
result

1

Surface

"In one sentence, compare the tax's immediate effect on drink sales with its downstream effect on public health."

2

Deep

"Using mechanism, explain what specifically has to happen between the price increase and any change in health outcomes."

3

Transfer

"Write one complex sentence connecting the trigger to the downstream effect, using in turn or as a direct result."

Instructor note: score for lexicon use and whether the mechanism step is traceable step by step — not for whether the tax is good policy.

Visual Synthesis

Forces students to infer the difference between a direct cause and a systemic, feedback-loop cause from grouped, unlabeled examples — no rule is stated up front.

Box A

- A bridge collapses because a support beam fractures under weight.
- A company's profits drop because a major client cancels their contract.
- A crop fails because a drought destroys the plants directly.

Box B

- A bridge collapses because decades of deferred maintenance funding created a slow-building weakness that a routine load finally exposed.
- A company's profits drop because a competitor's price cut triggers a price war that erodes margins across the industry, including the company's other product lines.
- A crop fails because reduced snowpack years earlier lowered the water table, so a mild dry spell leaves no groundwater reserve to fall back on.

TASK

Both boxes explain a collapse, a profit drop, and a crop failure. What is different about how Box A and Box B explain their outcomes? Why is a Box B–style explanation a stronger causal analysis at ILR 3?

Instructor note: Box A collapses trigger straight into effect; Box B traces a mechanism with steps and time delay. Let the student name that difference before you confirm it.

Silent Modeling & Pre-Attempt Brief-Back

Separates rule comprehension from production. Students extract the frame's structure from a marked-but-unexplained model, then must plan out loud before they're allowed to attempt their own response.

PHASE 1 — SILENT MODELING

Read the response below. Three elements are marked [A], [B], [C]. No explanation is given — identify what each represents before moving to Phase 2.

[A] The city's new tax raises the price of sugary drinks at checkout — an immediate change shoppers notice right away. **[B]** Faced with the higher price, many switch to water, diet alternatives, or smaller portions — a shift that spreads through the population as the price difference becomes routine rather than novel. **[C]** Over several years, average per-capita sugar intake from beverages falls measurably, with the reduction showing up first in dental health records, long before it appears in broader obesity statistics.

Key (reveal only after Phase 2). In the digital version, each move is color-highlighted. In print, use letter markers above.



[A] = Trigger



[B] =
Mechanism



[C] =
Downstream
Effect

PHASE 2 — VERBAL BRIEF-BACK ("PLAN BEFORE YOU PRODUCE")

Before attempting your own response to the prompt below, say out loud — or write in one sentence — your plan for each of the frame's three moves. Do not begin your full response until you've stated your plan.

PROMPT FOR PHASE 2 ATTEMPT

"Should the tax rate increase every year to keep pace with inflation, or stay fixed at its introductory level?"

Instructor note: the brief-back is a planning checkpoint, not a rehearsal — keep it to one sentence. This models a legitimate strategy: a brief pause to organize before speaking.

Fallback Scaffolding

Tests whether the frame's core move survives without its own vocabulary — the ILR 3 skill of knowing what to do when the exact word isn't available.

CONSTRAINT

Answer the prompt below without using the words trigger, mechanism, or downstream effect.

PROMPT

"Should cities also tax sugary snacks, not just drinks?"

Fallback Strategies to Practice

a

Circumlocution

Instead of "mechanism," try "what actually makes that happen" or "the steps in between."

b

Term substitution

Instead of "trigger" / "downstream effect," try "what starts it off" / "what ends up happening later."

c

Self-correction

"What I mean is..." / "Let me put that another way..."

d

Hedging

"It seems to set off..." / "This tends to lead to..."

Instructor note: use after a student is reliably using the frame vocabulary — this is a stress test, not a first attempt.